

ago, my husband, Travis, was working a job that would constantly call him in at all hours of the night and weekend, far beyond the forty hours he put in every week. When he told me he wanted to take a \$20,000 pay cut to work a job with no nights, no on-call, and didn't require us to move, I was . . . eventually . . . all for it. Because we weren't spending on the edge of what we were earning, it was a change we could afford to make. Fulfilling work doesn't have to mean a pay cut, though it is great to have enough financial security to be able to choose it. And our hope is that this job can expand his skillset and lead to an even higher paying job opportunity in a few years. Sometimes we do spend in order to pursue fulfilling work, which can result in increased income. Earning a degree or investing in skill improvement can lead to raises, promotions, and new job opportunities in what you're already doing or in a completely new field. We've also seen people save a year's salary to go full-time in a side business that's starting to take off. We like to shed light on this aspect of different ways we may pursue fulfilling work or what our careers might look like because so much personal finance advice regarding income is one-sided. It's all "earn more." It's endless talk about charging what you're worth, negotiating, asking for more, job hopping for raises, and while all of that is good and useful, it's not always the best route or doable in certain seasons. Sometimes the right move is earning more and other times it's taking the pay cut or sacrificing a raise for a job you like in a location you love. While both are OK, we don't want you to leave this book thinking that you either *have* to earn more or that you *can't* earn more. You can decide if a pay raise, a pay cut, or pay maintenance is best for you and what you want from life. And, of course, if you feel your compensation doesn't match the effort you put in or that you have more to give and you want to be compensated appropriately for it, then you can improve it and you should be looking for opportunities to improve it.

As a social worker, I (Jill) experienced this firsthand. While in many ways my career provided purpose, early on I held roles that were incredibly depleting both emotionally and financially because I thought that was my lot in life as a result of the field I'd chosen. I was serving as a clinical case manager for at-risk youth in a group home working sixty hours a week for \$24,000 a year. I was underpaid and overworked in every sense of the phrase. I knew the organization was suffering financially, and I thought it was my duty to sacrifice earning a livable wage for the sake of the teens I cared for deeply. I thought that I couldn't ask to be compensated more and